

Who is a Family Doctor?

A family doctor, also known as a family physician, is a healthcare professional who provides ongoing medical care for people of all ages, from infants to older adults. They are often your first point of contact for non-emergency health concerns and play an important role in helping you maintain your overall health throughout your life. Having a regular family doctor means you receive continuous, personalized care from someone who understands your medical history and health needs.

What Does a Family Doctor Do?

A family doctor provides a wide range of healthcare services, including:

- . Diagnosing and treating common illnesses and minor injuries.
- . Performing routine health check-ups and preventive screenings.
- . Providing vaccinations and immunizations.
- . Managing chronic conditions such as diabetes, asthma, and high blood pressure.
- . Prescribing medications and monitoring treatment plans.
- . Ordering and explaining laboratory tests, X-rays, and other medical investigations.
- . Referring patients to specialists when additional care is needed.
- . Offering health education and advice on healthy living, nutrition, mental health, and disease prevention.
- . Coordinating your healthcare with hospitals, specialists, and other healthcare providers.

For more information about your personal information, call Manitoba Health at 204-786-7111 in Winnipeg (toll free at 1-866-690-8260) Monday to Friday between 8:30 a.m. and 4:30 p.m.; TTY/TDD call 204-774-8618 or Manitoba Relay Services toll-free 1-800-855-0511.

Find a Family Doctor- *This is an external link to register for a family doctor.*

[Family Doctor Finder](#)

What is a Walk-in Clinic?

A walk-in clinic is a healthcare facility where you can see a doctor or nurse practitioner without making an appointment in advance. Walk-in clinics are a good option when you have a minor illness or injury that needs medical attention but is not serious enough to require a visit to the emergency department. They often have shorter wait times than hospitals and provide convenient access to care when your family doctor is unavailable.

What Can a Walk-in Clinic Help With?

Walk-in clinics can provide care for many common health concerns, including:

Colds, flu, sore throat, and ear infections.

Minor cuts, sprains, and burns.

Skin rashes and allergic reactions.

Urinary tract infections (UTIs) and other minor infections.

Prescription renewals or short-term medications.

Basic health assessments and referrals to specialists if needed.

Ordering simple laboratory tests or X-rays when appropriate.

Walk-in clinics are **not** meant for life-threatening emergencies such as severe chest pain, difficulty breathing, major injuries, or uncontrolled bleeding. In those situations, call **911** or go to the nearest emergency department immediately.

How They Work

Because they operate on a first-come, first-served system, wait times can fluctuate wildly depending on the time of day or how busy the flu season is. You might wait twenty minutes, or you might wait two hours.

You also won't always see the same doctor twice. Walk-in clinics are staffed by a rotation of physicians, so while they will take notes in a chart for your next visit, they don't provide the same deep, long-term personal connection that a regular family doctor does.

When to Skip the Walk-In

Walk-in clinics have their limits. They are not built to handle chronic disease management (like long-term diabetes or complex heart conditions), and they are absolutely not equipped for major medical emergencies. If you are experiencing chest pain, severe shortness of breath, sudden numbness, or a major broken bone, you need to head straight to an emergency room instead. they

Urgent Care Centre

An Urgent Care Centre treats health problems that need medical attention the same day but are **not life-threatening**. These centres are a good option when your condition cannot wait for a family doctor or walk-in clinic, but you do not need emergency care.

Visit an Urgent Care Centre if you have:

Minor fractures or sprains.

Deep cuts that may need stitches.

Moderate burns.

High fever that is not improving.

Asthma flare-ups that are not severe.

Minor infections or worsening illness that needs prompt treatment.

How to get help:

Visit your nearest urgent care centre during its operating hours. Many centres accept walk-in patients, while some allow you to check wait times or register online before you arrive.

Emergency Room (ER)

An Emergency Room (ER) is for serious or life-threatening medical emergencies that require immediate care. Emergency departments are open 24 hours a day and are equipped to treat severe injuries, illnesses, and conditions that could become dangerous if not treated quickly.

Go to the Emergency Room if you have:

Chest pain or signs of a heart attack.

Difficulty breathing.

Severe bleeding that won't stop.

Stroke symptoms (sudden weakness, trouble speaking, or facial drooping).

Serious head injuries or major fractures.

Loss of consciousness or seizures.

Severe allergic reactions or poisoning.

How to get help:

Call **911** if the situation is life-threatening or you cannot safely travel.

If it is safe to do so, go directly to the nearest hospital emergency department.

Know the difference between Emergency Room and Urgent Care

If your condition is life-threatening, call 911 or go to the Emergency Room immediately. If your illness or injury is urgent but not life-threatening, an Urgent Care Centre can often provide faster treatment and help reduce unnecessary visits to the emergency department.

Unlike urgent care, the ER does not operate on a first-come, first-served basis. A nurse will evaluate you when you arrive. The sickest and most critically injured patients are always taken to the back first, meaning if you go to the ER for a minor issue, you will likely face a very long wait.

Finding and Registering with a Family Doctor

Having a family doctor is one of the best ways to manage your health in Canada. A family doctor provides ongoing care, keeps track of your medical history, and can refer you to specialists when needed. If you are new to Canada or do not already have a family doctor, there are several ways to find one.

How to Find a Family Doctor

Use your province's **Find a Doctor** or **Doctor Finder** service to search for clinics accepting new patients.

Ask friends, family members, or settlement organizations for recommendations.

Contact nearby medical clinics to ask if they are accepting new patients.

If you visit a walk-in clinic regularly, ask whether any doctors are accepting new patients.

Call your provincial health information line (such as **Health Links – Info Santé** in Manitoba) for assistance finding a doctor in your area.

How to Register

Once you find a clinic accepting new patients:

Contact the clinic by phone or online.

Complete a new patient registration form.

Provide your health card and identification if requested.

Schedule your first appointment to discuss your health history and any ongoing medical needs.

Registering with a family doctor helps ensure you receive continuous, coordinated care whenever you need medical attention.

How to Register for Family Doctor For Each Province

Ontario

[Ontario Health Care Connect](#)

British Columbia

[BC College of Family Physicians](#)

Medical appointment expectation

Expectations for Medical Appointment

While it may be challenging navigating the healthcare system as a newcomer, here a few tips to help: Preparing for a medical appointment can help you make the most of your visit and ensure you receive the care you need. Before your appointment, gather important health information such as your current medications, medical history, and a list of any symptoms or questions you want to discuss. During the appointment, communicate openly with your healthcare provider, ask questions if anything is unclear, and take note of any advice or treatment recommendations. After your visit, follow your care plan, schedule any recommended tests or follow-up appointments, and monitor your health. Being prepared and actively involved in your healthcare can lead to better communication, more informed decisions, and improved health outcomes.

Ways to maximize your medical appointment <https://youtu.be/BincCVI-YsI>

2 mins

Before Your Medical Appointment

1. Book the Right Type of Appointment

When scheduling your appointment, explain the main reason for your visit. Whether you're experiencing new symptoms, need a routine check-up, require a prescription refill, or want to discuss test results, giving accurate information helps the clinic book enough time and ensure you see the appropriate healthcare provider.

2. Gather Important Health Information

Before your appointment, collect any information that may help your healthcare provider understand your health. This includes:

Your current medications (prescription, over-the-counter, vitamins, and supplements)

Previous medical conditions or surgeries

Recent test results or medical reports

Allergies to medications or foods

Vaccination history (if relevant)

Having this information readily available can prevent delays and improve the accuracy of your care.

3. Keep a Record of Your Symptoms

Think about what prompted you to make the appointment. Write down details such as:

When your symptoms started

How often they occur

What makes them better or worse

How severe they are

Any changes you've noticed over time

Being able to clearly describe your symptoms helps your healthcare provider make a more informed assessment.

4. Write Down Your Questions and Concerns

It's common to forget questions once you're in the examination room. Before your visit, make a list of everything you'd like to discuss, prioritizing your most important concerns first. This helps ensure you leave with the information you need.

Examples include:

What could be causing my symptoms?

Are there treatment options?

Do I need additional tests?

What side effects should I watch for?

5. Bring Necessary Documents

Depending on your clinic or province, you may need:

Health insurance or provincial health card

Photo identification

Referral forms

Medication list

Previous medical records (if requested)

Having these documents available makes the check-in process smoother.

6. Arrive Early

Plan to arrive approximately 10–15 minutes before your appointment. This allows time to:

Complete paperwork

Update your medical information

Confirm insurance or health coverage

Ask questions at reception if needed

Arriving early reduces stress and helps keep appointments on schedule.

7. Consider Bringing a Support Person

If you're anxious, have difficulty understanding medical information, require language assistance, or expect to receive important news, consider bringing a trusted family member or friend. They can help remember instructions, ask questions, and provide emotional support.

During your appointment

Your healthcare provider will listen to your concerns, ask questions about your symptoms and medical history, and may perform a physical examination if needed. This is your opportunity to ask questions, discuss treatment options, and make sure you understand your diagnosis and care plan before leaving.

1. Explain Your Main Concern Clearly

Start by describing the primary reason for your visit. Use simple, honest language and explain:

What you're experiencing

When it started

How it affects your daily life

Any treatments you've already tried

Providing clear information helps your healthcare provider better understand your condition.

2. Answer Questions Honestly

Your healthcare provider may ask about your:

Medical history

Lifestyle

Diet

Sleep habits

Physical activity

Smoking or alcohol use

Mental health

Sexual health (when relevant)

Answering honestly allows them to recommend the safest and most appropriate care.

3. Share Any Changes in Your Health

Mention any new symptoms, recent hospital visits, medications you've started or stopped taking, allergies, or major life changes that may affect your health.

4. Ask Questions if You Don't Understand

Healthcare information can sometimes be confusing. If something isn't clear, ask your provider to explain it in simpler language.

For example:

"Can you explain that another way?"

"Can you write that down?"

"Could you show me how to take this medication?"

Understanding your care is an important part of making informed decisions.

5. Participate in Decisions About Your Care

Healthcare decisions should be made together. Your provider may discuss:

Different treatment options

Benefits and risks

Possible side effects

Lifestyle recommendations

Follow-up care

Don't hesitate to ask about alternatives if you're unsure which option is best for you.

6. Take Notes

Write down important information during the appointment, including:

Diagnosis

Medication instructions

Lifestyle recommendations

Tests ordered

Follow-up appointments

If allowed, you can also ask if it's okay to record instructions on your phone.

7. Understand the Next Steps Before Leaving

Before your appointment ends, make sure you know:

What your diagnosis is (if available)

Whether you need laboratory tests or imaging

When you'll receive results

When to return for follow-up

Who to contact if your symptoms worsen

Leaving with a clear plan helps prevent confusion later.

After Medical Appointment

After your medical appointment, you may receive a diagnosis, treatment plan, or recommendations to help manage your health. This could include taking prescribed medications, making lifestyle changes, scheduling follow-up appointments, or completing additional tests such as blood work or imaging. Be sure to review any instructions provided by your healthcare provider, ask for clarification if needed, and monitor your symptoms. If your condition changes, worsens, or you experience unexpected side effects, contact your healthcare provider promptly or seek emergency medical care if necessary. Following your care plan and staying engaged in your treatment are important steps toward achieving better health outcomes.

1. Follow Your Treatment Plan

Take medications exactly as prescribed and follow any instructions provided by your healthcare provider. If you experience side effects or have concerns, contact your clinic before stopping treatment.

2. Schedule Recommended Tests or Referrals

If your provider recommends blood work, imaging, or referral to a specialist, book these appointments as soon as possible to avoid unnecessary delays in your care.

3. Monitor Your Symptoms

Pay attention to how you're feeling after the appointment.

Notice whether:

Symptoms improve

Symptoms stay the same

New symptoms develop

Side effects occur

Keeping a symptom diary can be helpful for future appointments.

4. Make Healthy Lifestyle Changes

If your provider recommends changes to your daily habits, start gradually.

Examples include:

Eating a balanced diet

Exercising regularly

Improving sleep habits

Managing stress

Quitting smoking

Limiting alcohol consumption

Small, consistent changes can have a significant impact on your overall health.

5. Review Your Visit Summary

Many clinics provide an after-visit summary through a patient portal or printed handout. Review it carefully to make sure you understand:

Your diagnosis

Medications

Test requests

Follow-up appointments

Home care instructions

6. Keep Your Health Records Updated

Store copies of important documents such as:

Test results

Imaging reports

Referral letters

Medication lists

Immunization records

Having your records organized makes future healthcare visits easier.

7. Know When to Seek Immediate Medical Care

Some symptoms require urgent medical attention rather than waiting for your next appointment. Seek emergency care or contact your healthcare provider immediately if you experience:

Difficulty breathing

Severe chest pain

Sudden weakness or numbness

Loss of consciousness

Heavy bleeding

High fever that doesn't improve

Severe allergic reactions

Symptoms that rapidly worsen

Understanding Health Insurance, Coverage and Claims

Understanding health insurance in Canada can feel confusing, especially if you are accustomed to a different healthcare system. The first thing to understand is that Canada does not have one national insurance plan that directly manages everyone's healthcare. Each province or territory administers its own public health insurance program and determines who is eligible, how to apply and which services are covered.

Health expenses may be paid through **public health insurance, private or workplace insurance**, a temporary government program, or directly by the patient. Following the steps below can help you understand your coverage and avoid unexpected expenses.

Step 1: Identify the Types of Insurance Available to You

Public provincial or territorial health insurance

Public health insurance pays for many medically necessary services, particularly appointments with physicians and treatment received in hospitals. Eligible residents must register with the health insurance program in the province or territory where they live and obtain a health card.

For example, eligible Manitoba residents can apply for a Manitoba Health Card. Eligibility depends on factors such as immigration status, residency and the length or conditions of a work permit. Permanent residents, Canadian citizens, protected persons and certain work-permit holders may qualify. ([Government of Manitoba](#))

Public insurance generally does not mean that every health-related service is free. Services such as routine dental care, prescription medications taken outside a hospital, eye examinations, physiotherapy, counselling, medical equipment and ambulance transportation may not be fully covered. Coverage differs across provinces and may also depend on a person's age, income or medical circumstances.

Private or workplace health insurance

Private insurance helps pay for healthcare products and services that are not fully covered by the public system. A plan may be purchased individually, provided through an employer or offered through a school.

Depending on the policy, it may help pay for:

Prescription medications

Dental examinations and treatment

Vision care and eyeglasses

Physiotherapy, massage therapy or chiropractic services

Mental-health counselling

Medical equipment

Emergency medical care while travelling

Private policies differ significantly. Having private insurance does not automatically mean the insurer will pay the entire bill.

Temporary health coverage

Newcomers who are not yet eligible for provincial coverage may need temporary private insurance. Certain refugees, protected persons and refugee claimants may qualify for the federal government's **Interim Federal Health Program**, which provides limited and temporary coverage based on immigration status and eligibility category. ([Canada](#))

Do not assume that temporary coverage begins automatically. Confirm your eligibility, effective date and covered services before receiving non-emergency care.

Step 2: Apply for Your Provincial or Territorial Health Card

Apply for public health coverage as soon as possible after arriving in your province or territory. The required documents commonly include:

A passport or another identity document

Permanent-resident documents, a work permit, study-related documents or proof of protected status

Proof that you live in the province, such as a lease, utility bill or government correspondence

Documents for a spouse and dependent children included in the application

The exact documents depend on the province and your immigration status. Manitoba determines eligibility using proof of legal status in Canada and proof of residence in Manitoba. ([Government of Manitoba](#))

After receiving your health card, check that your name, date of birth and personal health identification information are correct. Keep the card secure and take it to medical appointments. In Manitoba, the card contains a registration number and a Personal Health Identification Number, commonly called a PHIN. ([Government of Manitoba](#))

You should also update the provincial health authority when you:

Change your address

Change your legal name

Have a baby or need to add a dependent

Change your immigration status

Replace an expired immigration document

Lose or damage your health card

Step 3: Learn What Your Public Plan Covers

Before seeking care, learn which services your provincial plan pays for. Public health insurance commonly covers medically necessary appointments with physicians, hospital services and certain diagnostic tests ordered by an authorized healthcare provider.

However, coverage may depend on:

Whether the service is considered medically necessary

Whether the healthcare professional is recognized by the provincial plan

Where the service is provided

Whether a referral is required

Whether the treatment is received inside or outside the province

Whether you are eligible on the date of treatment

Ask the clinic the following before your appointment:

“Is this service covered by my provincial health card?”

“Will I need to pay any fee?”

“Is this healthcare provider enrolled in the provincial plan?”

“Do I need a referral before receiving this service?”

Do not assume that a service is covered simply because it is provided inside a medical clinic.

Step 4: Read Your Private Insurance Benefits Carefully

When you receive workplace, school or private insurance, you will usually be given a benefits booklet, online portal or mobile application. Read the section for each type of service you may use.

Pay attention to the following terms:

Eligible expense

An eligible expense is a service or product that the insurer allows under the policy. A service can be medically helpful but still be ineligible under your particular plan.

Coverage percentage

The insurer may pay only a percentage of the eligible cost. For example, a plan that provides 80% coverage may pay \$80 of an eligible \$100 expense, leaving you responsible for \$20.

Deductible

A deductible is an amount you must pay before the insurance plan begins paying. It may apply once per year, once per person or to a particular type of service.

Copayment

A copayment is a set amount that you pay toward a service or prescription. For example, you may be required to pay a fixed dispensing fee or a portion of every appointment.

Annual or lifetime maximum

An annual maximum is the most the plan will pay for a service during a benefit year. A plan may cover 80% of physiotherapy costs but stop paying after the annual maximum has been reached.

Reasonable and customary limit

Some insurers set a maximum amount they consider reasonable for a particular service. When a provider charges more than this amount, you may be responsible for the difference.

Exclusion

An exclusion is something the policy does not cover. Cosmetic procedures, missed-appointment fees, certain experimental treatments and services provided by unrecognized practitioners may be excluded.

Waiting period

Some plans require new members to wait for a certain period before particular benefits can be used.

Preauthorization

Preauthorization means you must obtain the insurer's approval before purchasing an expensive medication, medical device or treatment. Without approval, the claim may be refused even when the service appears in your benefits booklet.

Step 5: Confirm Coverage Before Receiving Care

Before booking a service that may not be publicly covered, contact your insurer or check your benefits portal.

Confirm:

Whether the service is included

The percentage the plan will pay

Your remaining annual balance

Whether a doctor's referral is required

Whether the provider must have a particular licence or registration

Whether preauthorization is required

Whether there is a deductible or copayment

Whether the provider can bill the insurer directly

When contacting the insurer, record the date, the representative's name or reference number, and the information provided. Coverage information is helpful, but final payment may still depend on the details submitted with the claim.

For an expensive treatment, ask the healthcare provider for a written cost estimate. You may be able to send this estimate to the insurer as a **predetermination** or **pre-treatment estimate** before agreeing to the service.

Step 6: Present the Correct Insurance Information

At an appointment, show your provincial health card for publicly insured services.

For services covered by a private plan, you may also need to provide:

The insurer's name

Your plan or policy number

Your member or certificate number

Your date of birth

The policyholder's information if the plan belongs to a parent, spouse or guardian

A secondary insurance plan, when applicable

Ensure the clinic has your correct name and address. A difference between the name on the receipt and the name registered with the insurer may delay the claim.

Step 7: Understand How Payment and Claims Work

A **claim** is a request asking an insurance program to pay for an eligible healthcare service or product.

There are three common payment arrangements.

Public-plan billing

For an insured doctor or hospital service, the provider will usually record your health-card information and bill the provincial plan. You normally do not submit the claim yourself.

However, you may be required to pay when the service is not publicly insured, when you are not eligible on the date of service, or when your health-card information cannot be confirmed.

Direct billing to a private insurer

Some dental offices, pharmacies, therapists and other providers can submit a private claim electronically on your behalf.

The insurer may pay its share directly to the provider. You then pay the remaining balance, including deductibles, copayments, excluded charges and amounts above the plan's limit.

Direct billing does not guarantee full payment. You remain responsible for any portion the insurer does not cover.

Paying first and requesting reimbursement

When direct billing is unavailable, you may need to pay the entire bill and submit the claim yourself. If approved, the insurer reimburses the eligible amount by direct deposit or cheque.

Step 8: Collect the Documents Needed for a Claim

Keep the original detailed receipt. A payment-card slip by itself may not contain enough information.

A proper receipt may need to include:

The patient's full name

The date the service was provided

A description of the service or product

The amount charged and the amount paid

The healthcare provider's name

The provider's registration or license number

The clinic's contact information

A prescription or referral, when required

A drug identification number for prescription medication

Proof of payment

Take a clear photograph or scan of every document before submitting it.

Step 9: Submit the Claim Correctly

Claims may usually be submitted through the insurer's website, mobile application, email system or paper claim form.

When completing the form:

Enter the patient's information exactly as it appears on the insurance plan.

Select the correct service category.

Enter the service date and amount.

Provide the healthcare professional's information.

Upload the itemized receipt.

Include a prescription, referral or preauthorization document when required.

Review the information carefully.

Submit the claim before the plan's deadline.

Save the confirmation or claim reference number.

Do not submit the same expense twice unless the insurer instructs you to correct and resubmit it.

Step 10: Review the Explanation of Benefits

After processing the claim, the insurer usually provides an **Explanation of Benefits** or claim statement. This document explains:

The amount charged by the provider

The amount considered eligible

The percentage covered

The deductible or copayment applied

The amount paid by the insurer

The amount you must pay

The reason any portion was denied

Your remaining benefit balance

For example, a provider may charge \$150, but the insurer may recognize only \$120 as an eligible or reasonable amount. If the policy covers 80%, the insurer may pay \$96, leaving you responsible for the remaining amount.

Compare the statement with your receipt and bank deposit to confirm that the correct amount was paid.

Step 11: Coordinate Two Insurance Plans

Some people are covered by more than one private insurance plan, such as their own workplace plan and a spouse's plan. This is called **coordination of benefits**.

The first insurer processes the claim and provides a claim statement. The unpaid eligible balance can then be submitted to the second insurer. The two plans cannot reimburse more than the total amount that was actually paid.

The correct submission order depends on whose expense is being claimed and the insurers' coordination rules. Ask both insurers which plan must receive the claim first.

Step 12: Respond to a Delayed or Denied Claim

A claim may be delayed or denied because:

Information is missing or incorrect

The service is excluded

The provider is not eligible under the plan

A referral or prescription was not provided

Preauthorization was required

The annual maximum was already reached

The claim was submitted after the deadline

Coverage had not started or had ended

The receipt did not contain enough information

Read the reason given on the claim statement. Then contact the insurer and ask:

“What specific information is missing?”

“Which policy rule was used to deny the claim?”

“Can I correct and resubmit it?”

“What is the appeal or review process?”

Request additional documentation from the provider when necessary. Keep copies of correspondence, receipts, claim statements and reference numbers.

Step 13: Understand Prescription-Drug Coverage

Public health insurance does not always pay the full cost of prescription medications obtained from a community pharmacy. Drug costs may be covered through private insurance, a provincial drug program or a combination of both.

In Manitoba, the Pharmacare program assists eligible residents whose prescription-drug costs are high in relation to their income. Eligibility and the amount a household must pay depend on the program's rules and application information. ([Government of Manitoba](#))

Before filling a prescription, ask the pharmacist:

Is this medication covered by my plan?

Is there a lower-cost generic version?

Does the insurer require special authorization?

How much will I need to pay?

Can the pharmacy bill my insurer directly?

Step 14: Keep Your Insurance Information Updated

Notify your public and private insurers when your personal circumstances change, including:

Moving to a new address

Moving to another province

Changing your name

Getting married or separated

Having or adopting a child

Starting or leaving a job

Beginning or finishing school

Receiving a new immigration document

Losing eligibility under another person's plan

A change in employment, immigration status or province of residence can affect when coverage begins or ends.

Step 15: Protect Yourself From Unexpected Bills

Before receiving non-emergency treatment:

Confirm that your coverage is active.

Ask whether the service is publicly insured.

Check your private plan's coverage percentage and limits.

Confirm whether the provider is recognized by the insurer.

Ask about deductibles, copayments and exclusions.

Obtain preauthorization when required.

Request a written estimate for costly care.

Keep all receipts and claim statements.

Review the final amount paid by the insurer.

Ask questions before agreeing to costs you do not understand.

Understand health claims and insurance -https://youtu.be/sJ0-sKg_krQ

15 mins

Important Reminder

Public health coverage, private insurance and temporary newcomer programs serve different purposes. Your health card may cover a medically necessary physician appointment but not the medication, dental treatment, therapy or equipment recommended afterward. Always check both your provincial coverage and any private plan you hold.

In a medical emergency, seek urgent care first. Do not delay emergency treatment because you are uncertain about insurance. Financial and coverage questions can be addressed with the hospital, provincial health authority or insurer after immediate safety needs have been managed.

Understanding your insurance is an ongoing process. Read your policy, keep your information current, confirm coverage before non-emergency care and carefully review every claim statement. These steps can help you use the healthcare system confidently while reducing the risk of unexpected costs.

Emergency Health Contact

When moving to or living in Canada, navigating the emergency health system is straightforward once you know the essential 3-digit and toll-free numbers. All of these services are **free**, available **24/7**, and offer **multilingual translation services** upon request.

Here is a guide to the key emergency and health support numbers you should save in your phone immediately.

1. Life-Threatening Emergencies: 911

When to call: Severe injuries, chest pain, difficulty breathing, major accidents, unconsciousness, severe allergic reactions, or active crimes/fires.

What happens: The operator will ask whether you need **Police, Fire, or Ambulance**.

Key details:

Free to call from any cell phone or landline (even without a active mobile plan/SIM card balance).

If you do not speak English or French, state your primary language immediately (e.g., *"Arabic, please"* or *"Spanish, please"*) to be connected to an interpreter.

2. Non-Emergency Health Advice: 811 (Telehealth)

When to call: You or a family member feel sick or injured, but it is **not** life-threatening, and you aren't sure whether to go to an emergency room, a walk-in clinic, or stay home.

What happens: You will speak to a Registered Nurse who assesses symptoms and provides health advice or guides you to local medical services.

Coverage: Available in almost all provinces and territories (Ontario, BC, Quebec, Alberta, Manitoba, Atlantic Canada, etc.).

3. Mental Health & Crisis Support: 988

When to call/text: If you or someone you know is experiencing distress, mental health crises, or thoughts of suicide.

What happens: Connects you immediately with a trained crisis responder.

Key details:

Free, confidential, and available 24/7/365 via call or text message.

4. Poisoning & Chemical Exposure: 1-844-POISON-X (1-844-764-7669)

When to call: If anyone accidentally swallows, inhales, or touches toxic household chemicals, cleaning agents, unfamiliar medications, or plants.

What happens: Automatically routes your call to your local provincial Poison Control Center for immediate instructions.

Note: If the person is unconscious or stopped breathing, skip this and call **911** immediately.

5. Social & Health Community Resources: 211

When to call: Finding community health services, newcomer settlement supports, food assistance, shelter listings, or non-emergency community care programs.

What happens: Connects you to local health and social service navigators who help point you to local government and non-profit support programs.

Common Lab Tests You Should Know

Laboratory tests are a routine part of healthcare in Canada. A doctor or other healthcare provider may order a blood, urine or other laboratory test to investigate symptoms, monitor an existing condition, check how a treatment is working or assess certain aspects of your health.

Not everyone needs the same tests. Your healthcare provider decides which tests are appropriate based on factors such as your symptoms, age, health history, medications and individual health needs.

Complete Blood Count (CBC)

A **CBC** measures different components of the blood, including red blood cells, white blood cells, hemoglobin and platelets.

It may help healthcare providers investigate concerns such as anemia, infection and certain blood-related conditions. For example, hemoglobin levels can provide useful information when assessing whether someone may have anemia.

Blood Glucose and A1C

These tests provide information about blood sugar.

A **blood glucose test** measures the amount of glucose in the blood at the time the sample is taken. An **A1C test** provides an estimate of average blood glucose over the previous few months.

They may be used when screening for, diagnosing or monitoring diabetes and other blood-sugar concerns.

Lipid Panel

A lipid panel measures fats in the blood, including **cholesterol and triglycerides**.

The results can help healthcare providers assess cardiovascular risk alongside other factors such as age, blood pressure, smoking history, diabetes and family history. A single cholesterol number does not determine someone's overall heart-health risk by itself.

Kidney Function Tests

Blood tests such as **creatinine and estimated glomerular filtration rate (eGFR)** provide information about how well the kidneys are filtering the blood.

Kidney function may be checked as part of investigating certain health concerns, monitoring kidney disease or assessing the effects of some medications.

Liver Function Tests

Liver-related blood tests measure substances such as enzymes and proteins associated with liver function and health.

These tests may be ordered when investigating possible liver problems, monitoring an existing condition or checking how the body is responding to certain medications. Abnormal results do not automatically mean someone has liver disease and may require further assessment.

Urinalysis

A **urinalysis** examines a urine sample for substances or changes that may provide information about the urinary system and other aspects of health.

It may help investigate concerns such as urinary tract infections, kidney problems or certain metabolic conditions. Depending on the reason for testing, additional urine tests may be required.

Thyroid Tests

Thyroid testing commonly includes **thyroid-stimulating hormone (TSH)** and, when appropriate, other thyroid hormones.

These tests help assess whether the thyroid is functioning as expected. Thyroid problems can affect many body functions, including energy levels, heart rate and metabolism.

Iron and Vitamin Tests

Tests for **iron, ferritin, vitamin B12 or other nutrients** may be ordered when a healthcare provider suspects a deficiency or wants to investigate symptoms or abnormal blood results.

Testing is based on individual circumstances rather than routinely checking every vitamin or mineral.

Infectious Disease Testing

Depending on a person's symptoms, medical history, exposure risks and clinical circumstances, a healthcare provider may recommend testing for certain infections.

This can include testing for conditions such as **hepatitis, HIV, tuberculosis or sexually transmitted infections (STIs)**. Some newcomers may also encounter specific health screening as part of immigration processes, but immigration medical examinations are separate from routine healthcare after arriving in Canada.

Understanding Your Results

Lab results are usually compared with a **reference range**, but a result outside that range does not automatically mean something is wrong. Reference ranges can vary between laboratories, and results need to be interpreted alongside symptoms, medical history and other findings.

Ask your healthcare provider:

What was this test checking for?

What do my results mean for me?

Do I need another test or follow-up?

Knowing the names and purposes of common laboratory tests can make medical appointments less unfamiliar and help newcomers take a more active role in understanding their healthcare.

Why Lab Tests Are Ordered

Lab tests are ordered to help healthcare providers diagnose illnesses, monitor existing health conditions, guide treatment decisions, evaluate how well treatments are working, screen for diseases before symptoms appear, assess organ function, and ensure patient safety before medical procedures. They provide important objective data that supports accurate and timely patient care.

Clinicians order laboratory tests for several specific reasons. Instead of guessing what is happening inside the complex systems of your body, doctors use lab panels to gather objective, measurable data. A test generally falls into one of five main clinical categories:

Screening

Screening tests are performed when you feel completely healthy and have no symptoms. The goal is to detect chronic conditions early, when they are much easier to manage or reverse. Examples: Checking your cholesterol levels (lipid panel) or blood sugar (A1C) during an annual physical check-up to screen for cardiovascular disease or prediabetes. Why it matters: Many conditions, like high

blood pressure or early kidney strain, do not cause physical pain or symptoms until they have progressed significantly.

Diagnosing (Investigating Symptoms)

If you visit a clinic because you are feeling unwell, a doctor will use lab tests to rule out or confirm a specific medical condition. This helps narrow down a broad symptom like "fatigue" into a precise cause. The "Fatigue" Example: If you feel constantly exhausted, a doctor might order a Complete Blood Count (CBC) to check for anemia (low iron), a thyroid panel to check for hypothyroidism (sluggish metabolism), and a metabolic panel to check your kidney and liver function. Why it matters: Completely different medical issues can cause identical physical symptoms. Labs provide the cellular clarity needed to pinpoint the exact culprit.

Understanding Normal and Abnormal Test Results

Receiving your lab test results can sometimes be confusing, especially if you are unfamiliar with medical terms. It is important to remember that a lab result alone does not diagnose a disease. Healthcare providers interpret your results together with your symptoms, medical history, physical examination, medications, age, and other health factors before making any diagnosis or treatment decisions.

Normal Test Results

A **normal test result** means your result falls within the expected **reference range** established from healthy individuals. In most cases, this indicates that the body system being tested is functioning as expected.

However, a normal result does **not always mean that everything is perfect**. Some conditions may not show up in laboratory tests during their early stages, and certain illnesses require additional tests or imaging for diagnosis.

Examples of normal results include:

Blood sugar levels within the healthy range.

Cholesterol levels that indicate a lower risk of heart disease.

Kidney and liver function tests showing normal organ function.

Blood cell counts within the expected range, suggesting healthy production of red blood cells, white blood cells, and platelets.

If your results are normal, your healthcare provider may:

Reassure you that no further testing is currently needed.

Continue routine health monitoring.

Recommend maintaining healthy lifestyle habits such as balanced nutrition, regular exercise, adequate sleep, and avoiding smoking.

Abnormal Test Results

An **abnormal test result** means one or more values are **higher or lower than the reference range**. This does **not automatically mean you have a disease**.

Many factors can temporarily affect laboratory results, including:

Eating or drinking before the test

Dehydration

Recent exercise

Certain medications or supplements

Stress

Pregnancy

Menstrual cycle

Age and sex

Minor laboratory variation

For example:

A slightly elevated blood sugar level may occur after eating.

A low iron level could suggest iron deficiency but may require additional tests to determine the cause.

Elevated cholesterol may indicate an increased risk of heart disease and lead to recommendations for dietary changes or medication.

High white blood cell counts may suggest an infection or inflammation.

Abnormal thyroid hormone levels may indicate an overactive or underactive thyroid.

Some abnormal results are **mild and temporary**, while others may require prompt medical attention.

What Happens If Your Results Are Abnormal?

If your results are outside the normal range, your healthcare provider will explain what they mean and determine the appropriate next steps. Depending on the findings, they may:

Repeat the test to confirm the result.

Order additional laboratory tests or imaging studies.

Recommend lifestyle changes such as improving diet, increasing physical activity, or quitting smoking.

Prescribe medication if treatment is needed.

Refer you to a specialist for further evaluation.

Monitor your condition with follow-up appointments and repeat testing.

Don't Interpret Results on Your Own

Seeing a result marked "**High (H)**" or "**Low (L)**" can be concerning, but it does not necessarily indicate a serious medical condition. Reference ranges are based on large groups of healthy people, and some healthy individuals naturally fall slightly outside these ranges.

Only a qualified healthcare provider can accurately interpret your results by considering:

Your current symptoms

Your medical and family history

Previous test results

Your medications

Your overall health

If you have questions or concerns about your results, schedule a follow-up appointment with your healthcare provider rather than making assumptions based solely on the laboratory report.

Follow-Up Steps After a Medical Lab Test

Following up on medical lab results is a crucial part of managing your healthcare. Taking proactive, informed action ensures you receive proper care regardless of your test results.

Key Action Steps

1. Confirm Timing & Delivery: Before leaving, ask when and how your results will be delivered and who to contact. **Never assume "no news is good news."**

2. Review Results with a Professional: Discuss findings directly with your healthcare provider rather than self-diagnosing online. A single abnormal value does not necessarily mean a severe illness.

3. Understand Next Steps:

If Normal: Continue current health habits/treatments, but inform your doctor if symptoms persist.

If Abnormal: Remain calm—many issues are mild or temporary. Be prepared for potential repeat testing, imaging, medication adjustments, or specialist referrals.

4. Stick to the Treatment Plan: Take medications as prescribed, follow lifestyle/dietary guidance, and monitor health metrics (e.g., blood pressure, blood sugar) at home if advised.

5. Attend Follow-Up Care: Go to scheduled follow-up visits with your medication list, home health logs, and any questions.

6. Monitor Your Health: Contact your provider if symptoms worsen or side effects appear. **Seek emergency care immediately** for severe warning signs like chest pain or difficulty breathing.

7. Stay Organized: Keep copies of your lab reports, imaging, medications, and medical history in a personal record folder.

8. Maintain Healthy Habits: Support your long-term recovery and health through balanced nutrition, exercise, adequate sleep, hydration, and stress management.

Core Takeaway

Don't stop caring for your health once the lab sample is taken. Stay involved by getting your results interpreted by a professional, strictly following your recommended treatment plan, and keeping organized records.

Understanding Mental Health and Wellness for Newcomers

Mental health is an important part of overall health. It affects how people think, feel, manage stress, build relationships, make decisions, and carry out daily activities.

For newcomers, mental health can be influenced by the experience of migration as well as the process of settling into a new country. These experiences vary widely. Some people adjust quickly, while others may face periods of stress, uncertainty, loneliness, or emotional strain.

Mental health challenges after migration are not caused by one single factor. They can develop through a combination of social, financial, cultural, family, and settlement-related pressures.

How Migration Can Affect Mental Well-Being

Moving to a new country often involves significant changes in a short period of time. A newcomer may need to find housing, learn a new transportation system, understand healthcare and education systems, look for employment, complete immigration paperwork, and build new social connections. Even when these changes are positive, they can require substantial emotional and mental adjustment. Some people may experience stress during the first few weeks after arrival. For others, difficulties may become more noticeable later, after the initial period of settlement has passed. Research in Canada has shown that newcomer mental health is influenced by experiences before migration, during migration, and after arrival, including social and economic conditions in the new country.

Social Isolation and Loss of Support Networks

Many newcomers leave behind family members, close friends, neighbours, and established community networks. After arrival, a person may have fewer people to rely on for practical help or emotional support. Even when they regularly interact with coworkers, classmates, or neighbours, they may still feel socially disconnected. Social isolation may be especially noticeable during weekends, holidays, family events, or difficult periods when close relatives live in another country. Maintaining contact with family and friends abroad can be helpful, but it may not fully replace having a local support network.

Employment and Professional Adjustment

Employment can have a strong influence on mental well-being. Some newcomers arrive with years of education and professional experience but may face challenges such as: difficulty obtaining recognition for international credentials limited Canadian work experience language or communication barriers professional licensing requirements employment outside their previous field unemployment or underemployment These experiences can affect income, confidence, independence, and professional identity. Employment difficulties may also create additional pressure when a person is supporting family members in Canada or abroad.

Financial Stress

Settlement often involves significant expenses. Housing, groceries, transportation, childcare, tuition, immigration fees, and other daily costs can place pressure on household finances. Financial stress may become more difficult when employment is unstable or when a newcomer is supporting relatives in another country. Financial concerns can also affect other areas of health. For example, someone may reduce social activities, delay non-urgent services, work long hours, or have difficulty maintaining regular routines because of financial pressure.

Culture Shock and Adjustment

Culture shock refers to the emotional and practical adjustment that can occur when someone is living in an unfamiliar cultural environment. Differences may involve: communication styles workplace expectations parenting practices social relationships gender roles privacy healthcare expectations attitudes toward authority dating and relationships independence within families These differences are not necessarily negative, but learning unfamiliar social expectations can be tiring. Adjustment usually happens gradually. Many newcomers eventually develop routines and identities that combine aspects of their culture of origin with their life in Canada.

Mental Health Does Not Always Look the Same

Emotional distress may appear differently from person to person.

Some people may notice changes in mood, while others may experience physical or behavioural changes.

Possible signs include:

persistent tiredness

difficulty sleeping

changes in appetite

irritability

difficulty concentrating

frequent headaches or stomach discomfort

reduced interest in usual activities

withdrawing from family or friends

difficulty managing work, school, or daily responsibilities

The presence of one of these signs does not necessarily mean someone has a mental illness. However, persistent or worsening changes may indicate that additional support or medical assessment could be helpful.

Barriers to Seeking Mental Health Support

Newcomers may face practical and cultural barriers when trying to access mental-health services.

These can include:

not knowing where to seek help

concerns about cost

language barriers

long wait times

lack of culturally appropriate services

stigma surrounding mental illness

uncertainty about confidentiality

unfamiliarity with counselling or therapy

concerns about immigration or employment consequences

Settlement agencies, community health centres, primary-care providers, and newcomer organizations can help explain available services and connect people with appropriate supports.

Mental Wellness During Settlement

Mental wellness is supported by both individual well-being and the conditions surrounding a person.

Helpful supports may include:

stable housing

meaningful employment

social connection

access to healthcare

financial stability

community belonging

language support

family support

culturally appropriate services

For this reason, newcomer mental health should not be viewed only as an individual issue. Settlement conditions and access to community resources can have a significant influence on well-being.

When Professional Support May Be Appropriate

Professional support may be helpful when emotional or behavioural changes:

continue for an extended period

become more severe

interfere with daily activities

affect work or school

create significant problems in relationships

make it difficult to manage normal responsibilities

A family doctor or nurse practitioner can provide an initial assessment and discuss available options.

Depending on the situation, support may include counselling, community programs, peer support, mental-health services, or referral to another healthcare professional.

Settlement organizations may also help newcomers identify culturally appropriate or low-cost services.

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Managing Culture Shock, Anxiety and Stress

Adjusting to life in a new country can affect mental and emotional well-being. Newcomers may be dealing with unfamiliar systems, employment or financial pressures, separation from family, language differences, changing family roles and the challenge of building a new social network. Stress during this period may appear as worry, homesickness, tiredness, irritability, difficulty concentrating or changes in sleep.

Adjustment takes time, but several practical steps can make the settlement period easier to manage.

Build a Regular Routine

When many parts of life feel unfamiliar, having some predictability can help. Regular times for sleeping, eating, work or school, physical activity and rest can provide structure while other parts of settlement are still changing.

Stay Connected

Maintaining relationships with family and friends abroad can provide familiarity and emotional support. Building connections locally is equally important. Newcomer organizations, cultural associations, community centres, libraries, places of worship, volunteering and recreational programs can provide opportunities to meet people and become more connected to the community.

Keep Familiar Parts of Your Culture

Adjusting to Canada does not require leaving your culture behind. Familiar foods, languages, music, traditions, celebrations and cultural communities can provide comfort and continuity. Over time, newcomers may develop routines that combine familiar traditions with new experiences in Canada.

Deal With the Source of Stress

Not every settlement difficulty requires the same type of support. Identifying the problem can make it easier to find appropriate help.

Employment stress may require career or credential-recognition support. Language difficulties may be helped by language programs or interpretation services. Questions about housing, healthcare or government services may be easier to address with a settlement worker.

Practical support can be an important part of reducing stress.

Break Settlement Tasks Into Smaller Steps

Finding housing, applying for documents, looking for work, managing finances and learning new systems at the same time can become overwhelming.

Prioritize tasks that need immediate attention and work through less urgent responsibilities gradually. Keeping a simple list of completed and upcoming tasks can also make progress easier to see.

Protect Sleep, Rest and Physical Activity

Sleep, regular movement and adequate rest support mental well-being. Walking, recreational activities, community fitness programs or other forms of physical activity can be helpful.

Rest is also important. Settlement can sometimes feel like a continuous list of things to accomplish, particularly when work, school and family responsibilities happen at the same time.

Manage Moments of Anxiety

During periods of increased stress, simple strategies such as slowing your breathing, taking a short walk, writing down concerns, stepping away briefly from an overwhelming task or speaking with someone you trust may help.

These strategies can help manage temporary stress but should not replace professional support when anxiety or other symptoms persist or significantly affect daily life.

Know When to Seek Additional Support

Consider speaking with a healthcare or mental-health professional when changes in mood, sleep, concentration or behaviour continue, become more severe, or begin affecting work, school, relationships or everyday responsibilities.

A family doctor or nurse practitioner can provide an initial assessment and discuss available options. Counsellors, community mental-health programs and settlement organizations may also provide support or referrals.

Finding Support in Manitoba

211 Manitoba can help people find mental-health, community and social services in Manitoba. Support is available 24/7, and assistance is available in many languages.

Settlement organizations can help newcomers with employment, language learning, community connections and navigating services. They may also provide well-being support or referrals to appropriate healthcare and mental-health services.

Family doctors and nurse practitioners can discuss mental-health concerns, assess symptoms and connect patients with additional services when needed.

Manitoba Mental Health and Addictions services provide information about mental-health and community supports available throughout the province.

Remember

Culture shock and settlement stress can affect people differently and may change over time. Identifying **what is creating the most pressure** can help determine the most useful next step—whether that is community connection, settlement assistance, employment support or professional mental-health care.

Counselling & Mental Health Support in Canada

Mental-health care in Canada is available through the healthcare system, community organizations, settlement agencies, schools, workplaces and private providers. There is no single entry point. The most appropriate place to start depends on the type of support needed, eligibility, location and available health coverage.

Where Can I Get Support?

Free & Community Support

Community organizations and publicly funded programs may provide counselling, peer support, group programs, mental-health education and connections to other services. These can be useful when cost is a concern or when someone needs support close to their community.

Start with: community health centres, provincial mental-health programs, local organizations or community-service directories.

Counselling & Therapy

Counselling provides a confidential space to work through concerns such as anxiety, stress, grief, loneliness, family difficulties and adjustment to major life changes.

Counselling may be provided by counsellors, therapists, social workers or psychologists. Some services are free or publicly funded, while private counselling may be covered through workplace, student or private insurance.

Before booking: ask about fees, insurance coverage, language options and whether a referral is required.

Professional Mental Health Care

A family doctor or nurse practitioner can be a first point of contact when changes in mood, anxiety, sleep, concentration or daily functioning become difficult to manage. They can assess the concern, discuss treatment and arrange referrals when necessary.

Psychologists provide psychological assessment and therapy, while psychiatrists are medical doctors who can diagnose mental-health conditions and prescribe medication.

Start with: a family doctor, nurse practitioner, community health centre or provincial mental-health service.

Newcomer & Settlement Support

Mental well-being after migration is often connected with practical settlement conditions. Employment difficulties, housing, language barriers, immigration uncertainty, family separation and social isolation can all contribute to stress.

Settlement organizations can help with these underlying concerns while connecting newcomers with community, healthcare and mental-health services. Some organizations also provide culturally responsive programs and support in multiple languages.

Start with: a local settlement or newcomer-serving organization.

Student Support

Colleges and universities commonly provide counselling and wellness services for students. International students may also have mental-health benefits through their student health plan.

Services can include counselling, peer support, wellness programs, workshops and referrals to community care.

Start with: your institution's student wellness, counselling or health-services office.

Workplace Support

Some employers provide confidential mental-health support through an **Employee Assistance Program (EAP)** or extended health benefits.

EAPs may provide short-term counselling for personal, family, financial or workplace concerns. Extended benefits may also cover part of the cost of private counselling, psychology or social-work services.

Start with: your employee benefits information or EAP provider.

Will I Have to Pay?

Mental-health services are funded differently across Canada.

Care provided by physicians and psychiatrists through the public healthcare system is generally covered for eligible residents. Community organizations, settlement agencies and educational institutions may also provide services at no cost.

Private psychologists, counsellors, therapists and social workers may charge fees. These costs may be partly or fully covered by workplace benefits, student plans or private insurance.

Before using a private service, check **who is covered under your plan, how much is covered, whether a referral is required and whether there is an annual limit.**

Not Sure Where to Start?

The first step does not always need to be a mental-health clinic.

Settlement or immigration-related stress → Newcomer or settlement services

Stress affecting everyday health and functioning → Family doctor or nurse practitioner

Need someone to talk to regularly → Counselling or therapy

Student experiencing stress → Campus counselling or student wellness services

Employed with workplace benefits → EAP or extended health benefits

Cost is a barrier → Community or publicly funded services

Mental-health support can also be combined with practical support. Addressing housing, employment, language, financial or social difficulties may be an important part of improving well-being rather than treating these concerns separately.

What to Expect When Seeking Support

The first conversation usually focuses on understanding what has been happening, how it is affecting daily life and what kind of support may be appropriate.

It is reasonable to ask about **confidentiality, cost, language or interpretation services, cultural experience, appointment frequency and available treatment options** before deciding whether a service meets your needs.

Finding appropriate mental-health support may involve more than one service. For newcomers in particular, healthcare, counselling and settlement support can work together to address both emotional well-being and the circumstances contributing to stress.

Mental Health Resources in Manitoba

Manitoba has several mental-health services available through the healthcare system, community organizations and support programs. Some provide counselling directly, while others help people understand their concerns and find the appropriate service.

211 Manitoba — Find Mental Health and Community Services

211 Manitoba is a useful starting point for anyone who needs support but does not know which organization or program to contact.

The service connects people with mental-health, healthcare and community resources throughout Manitoba. It can also help locate services related to housing, food, employment, family support and other circumstances that may be contributing to stress or well-being.

211 is free, confidential, available 24 hours a day and offers assistance in many languages.

Contact: Dial **211**

Best for: Finding mental-health or community services when you are unsure where to start.

Health Links–Info Santé — Speak With a Nurse

Health Links–Info Santé is Manitoba's 24-hour telephone health-information service. Registered nurses provide health information, discuss symptoms and help callers determine what type of healthcare may be appropriate.

It can be a useful starting point when changes in stress, sleep, mood or other health concerns are occurring alongside physical symptoms, or when someone is unsure whether they should contact a healthcare provider.

Winnipeg: 204-788-8200

Toll-free in Manitoba: 1-888-315-9257

Best for: Health concerns when you are unsure what type of care you need.

Klinic Community Health — Free Counselling

Klinic Community Health provides free counselling and mental-health support in Winnipeg. Services include counselling and wellness programs, with options for people experiencing stress, anxiety, grief, relationship difficulties, major life changes and other concerns.

Klinic also provides **drop-in counselling**, which offers a confidential counselling session without requiring an ongoing counselling relationship. Interpretation can be requested, making the service more accessible when language is a barrier.

Counselling intake: 204-784-4059

General information: 204-784-4090

Location: 167 Sherbrook Street, Winnipeg

Best for: People looking for free counselling or someone to speak with about a personal or emotional concern.

WRHA Community Mental Health Services — Ongoing Mental Health Care

The **Winnipeg Regional Health Authority (WRHA) Community Mental Health Program** provides mental-health services for people living in Winnipeg who require more structured community-based care.

Depending on a person's needs and eligibility, services may include mental-health assessment, counselling, consultation, case management, rehabilitation and connections with other health or community services.

Community mental-health care can be particularly useful when mental-health concerns are persistent or are beginning to interfere significantly with everyday functioning.

Access: Through WRHA Community Mental Health Services and appropriate referral pathways.

Best for: People who may need ongoing assessment, treatment or community mental-health support rather than a single counselling session.

Canadian Mental Health Association — Manitoba and Winnipeg

The **Canadian Mental Health Association (CMHA) Manitoba and Winnipeg** provides mental-health education, community programs, recovery-oriented supports and assistance navigating available resources.

CMHA can be particularly useful for someone trying to better understand mental health, find community-based support or identify services that may be appropriate for their circumstances.

Phone: 204-982-6100

Location: 930 Portage Avenue, Winnipeg

Best for: Mental-health information, community support, recovery resources and help navigating services.

Kids Help Phone — Support for Children and Youth

Kids Help Phone provides confidential support for young people across Canada, including those living in Manitoba.

Young people can contact the service to talk about stress, school, relationships, family difficulties, loneliness, mental health and other concerns. Support is available by telephone and text, which can make it easier for young people who may not feel ready to discuss a concern in person.

Phone: 1-800-668-6868

Text: CONNECT to 686868

Best for: Children, teenagers and young people who want confidential support or someone to talk to.

Not Sure Which Service to Use?

The first contact does not have to be a mental-health specialist.

Need help finding a service? Start with **211 Manitoba**.

Have health concerns and are unsure where to seek care? Contact **Health Links–Info Santé**.

Looking for free counselling in Winnipeg? Contact **Klinic Community Health**.

Need ongoing community mental-health care? Explore **WRHA Community Mental Health Services**.

Looking for mental-health information or community programs? Contact **CMHA Manitoba and Winnipeg**.

Looking for support for a young person? **Kids Help Phone** provides confidential support across Manitoba.

Knowing what kind of support is needed can make the mental-health system easier to navigate. If the first service contacted is not the appropriate one, staff may also be able to provide information about other services or referral options.

Understanding Healthy Eating in a New Food Environment

Food is often one of the most familiar parts of home. After moving to Canada, however, even everyday decisions about what to eat can become less familiar. Ingredients may have different names, grocery stores may be organized differently, familiar foods may cost more, and new work or school schedules can change how meals are prepared.

Healthy eating during settlement is therefore not simply about learning what foods are “healthy.” It is about learning how to meet nutritional needs within a **new food environment while keeping culture, affordability and everyday life in mind**.

What Does Healthy Eating Mean?

Healthy eating means regularly eating a variety of foods that provide the nutrients the body needs for energy, growth, repair and normal body functions.

Canada’s Food Guide describes a healthy eating pattern that includes plenty of **vegetables and fruits, whole-grain foods and protein foods**, with water as the drink of choice. It also emphasizes eating habits—such as cooking more often, being mindful of eating habits and enjoying food with others—not simply individual nutrients.

A healthy eating pattern can support physical health, energy and overall well-being and can contribute to reducing the risk of conditions such as cardiovascular disease and type 2 diabetes.

Familiar Foods Can Still Be Part of Healthy Eating

Moving to Canada does not require adopting a completely different diet.

Traditional foods can provide important sources of fibre, protein, carbohydrates, vitamins and minerals. Beans and lentils, rice and other grains, fish, vegetables, fruits, meat, eggs, nuts, seeds, root vegetables and traditional soups or stews can all contribute to balanced eating.

Rather than labelling an entire cultural dish as “healthy” or “unhealthy,” it is more useful to consider **what the overall meal provides and how foods are eaten over time**.

For example, a familiar meal can be considered alongside simple questions:

Where are the vegetables or fruit?

What is providing protein?

What is providing energy, such as grains or other staple foods?

How often are highly processed foods and sugary drinks being consumed?

This approach allows nutrition information to complement cultural eating practices instead of replacing them.

Learning Canada's Food Environment

One of the first adjustments may happen at the grocery store.

Foods that were available year-round elsewhere may be seasonal or more expensive in Canada. Familiar ingredients may be found in international grocery stores rather than large supermarkets. The same food may also appear under a different name or be sold frozen, canned or dried instead of fresh.

Fresh food is not automatically the only nutritious option. **Frozen vegetables and fruit, dried beans and lentils, canned foods and other shelf-stable products** can make nutritious meals more practical, particularly during winter or when food costs are high.

The goal is not to shop for special “health foods.” It is to learn which available foods can provide good nutrition within the household's budget, culture and cooking habits.

Understanding Food Labels

Packaged foods in Canada generally include a **Nutrition Facts table** and ingredient list. These can be useful when comparing unfamiliar products.

The Nutrition Facts table provides information about nutrients such as sodium, fibre, sugars, fat and protein. The % **Daily Value (% DV)** provides a quick comparison:

5% DV or less is a little.

15% DV or more is a lot.

The ingredient list provides another view of the product. Ingredients are listed according to weight, beginning with those present in the greatest amount.

For someone encountering unfamiliar brands for the first time, labels can help answer a practical question: **Which of these similar products better fits what I am looking for?**

Affordability Is Part of Healthy Eating

Healthy eating recommendations need to make sense within the realities of food prices, household income, transportation and access to grocery stores.

Nutritious food does not have to come from expensive specialty products. Foods such as beans, lentils, eggs, oats, potatoes, rice, frozen vegetables and seasonal produce can form the basis of many affordable meals.

Planning meals around ingredients already at home, comparing unit prices, choosing frozen or canned alternatives when appropriate and using ingredients across several meals can also reduce food costs and waste.

Access matters as well. Someone living far from a grocery store, working irregular hours or supporting a large household may face different food choices from someone with more time and resources. Healthy eating information is most useful when those realities are considered.

Food Is Also Culture and Connection

Nutrition is only one reason people eat.

Food carries family traditions, memories, religion, celebrations and cultural identity. Sharing familiar meals can provide continuity during a period when many other parts of life are changing.

Settlement can also introduce new foods and eating practices. Over time, a household may keep traditional recipes, modify some ingredients, discover local alternatives and add new foods to its regular meals.

Healthy eating in Canada does not have to mean choosing between **“food from home”** and **“Canadian food.”** It can mean understanding the food environment well enough to make choices that are nutritious, affordable, culturally meaningful and realistic for everyday life.

Canada’s Food Guide

Canada’s Food Guide provides a simple approach to building balanced meals. It encourages eating a variety of nutritious foods while recognizing that healthy eating can include different cultures, traditions, preferences and ways of preparing food.

Build Your Plate

½ Vegetables and Fruits

Make vegetables and fruits a large part of your meals.

Fresh, frozen and canned options can all provide important nutrients. Choose different types when possible and use the vegetables and fruits that are familiar, affordable and available to you.

Try: leafy vegetables, carrots, tomatoes, peppers, broccoli, cabbage, berries, apples, oranges, mangoes or other fruits and vegetables you regularly enjoy.

¼ Whole-Grain Foods

Choose whole-grain foods regularly as part of your meals.

Whole grains provide fibre and other nutrients and can include whole-grain bread and pasta, oats, brown or wild rice, barley and quinoa.

Traditional grains and staple foods can still be part of your meals. The Food Guide plate is a flexible way to think about balance rather than a requirement to replace familiar foods.

¼ Protein Foods

Include a source of protein with your meals.

Protein foods include beans, peas, lentils, eggs, fish, poultry, meat, tofu, nuts, seeds, milk and yogurt. Canada's Food Guide recommends choosing plant-based protein foods more often.

Different cultural diets use different sources of protein, and these can be incorporated into the plate in ways that fit your household.

Make Water Your Drink of Choice

Water is recommended as the main drink for everyday hydration.

Tap water in Canada is generally safe to drink where local authorities have determined the water supply meets drinking-water standards. Local advisories should always be followed where they are in effect.

Choosing water more often can also reduce the amount of sugars consumed from soft drinks, fruit drinks and other sweetened beverages.

Healthy Eating Is More Than Your Plate

Food choices are important, but Canada's Food Guide also recognizes that how we eat matters.

Cook More Often

Preparing meals at home gives you more control over the ingredients used and can help reduce food costs. Cooking does not have to mean making unfamiliar meals. Traditional dishes and recipes from home can continue to be an important part of healthy eating in Canada.

Enjoy Your Food

Healthy eating should still include foods that are enjoyable and meaningful. Taste, culture, family traditions and personal preferences are all part of the eating experience. Nutritious eating does not require every meal to look the same.

Eat with others

Sharing meals can support social connection and make food an opportunity to spend time with family, friends and community. For newcomers living away from established family networks, shared meals can also be one way of maintaining cultural traditions and building new connections.

Use Food Labels

Canada's Nutrition Facts table can help you understand and compare packaged foods. Check the serving size first, then use the % Daily Value (% DV) to compare nutrients. As a general guide: 5% DV or less is a little. 15% DV or more is a lot. Food labels can be particularly helpful when comparing unfamiliar Canadian brands or similar products.

Plan Ahead

Planning a few meals before grocery shopping can help make food choices easier and reduce unnecessary spending and food waste. A plan can be as simple as deciding what meals you will prepare for the next few days and checking what ingredients you already have before shopping.

Culturally Adaptable Healthy Recipes

Moving to Canada may change which ingredients are easy to find, affordable, or available year-round. Culturally adaptable cooking helps newcomers keep familiar meals while making practical substitutions that fit local grocery options, budget, dietary needs, and nutrition.

Keep the Meal Familiar

Traditional foods do not need to be replaced to support healthy eating. Instead, small changes can be made while keeping the flavour and identity of the dish.

For example:

Ingredient unavailable?

Use a similar vegetable, grain, or protein that works in the same way.

Fresh food too expensive or out of season?

Frozen, canned, or dried alternatives can work well in soups, stews, curries, and sauces.

Protein costs are high?

Beans, lentils, chickpeas, eggs, or tofu can sometimes replace part of the meat in suitable dishes.

Use Familiar Flavours

New ingredients are often easier to introduce when they are prepared with familiar herbs, spices, sauces, and cooking methods. A locally available vegetable can be added to a traditional stew, or lentils can be prepared using seasonings already used at home.

Balance the Whole Meal

Rather than labelling a cultural dish as healthy or unhealthy, consider the meal as a whole.

Aim to include:

vegetables or fruit

a source of protein

grains or another staple food

water as the main drink

Canada's Food Guide can be used as a flexible guide without changing the cultural identity of the meal.

Make Recipes Easier to Adapt

HealthBridge recipes can include:

Original version — the traditional recipe

Canadian substitute — easier-to-find alternatives

Budget swap — lower-cost ingredients

Vegetarian option — where appropriate

Where to find it — suggestions for locating cultural ingredients

The goal is simple: **help newcomers cook nutritious meals with ingredients they can realistically find in Canada, while keeping the foods and flavours that feel familiar.**

Navigating Grocery Stores in Canada

Canadian grocery stores can take some time to get used to. Products may have unfamiliar names, familiar ingredients may be located in different sections, and the price displayed on the shelf may not always make it obvious which option offers better value.

Learn the Store Layout

Most grocery stores group similar products together. Fresh fruits and vegetables are usually in the **produce section**, while meat, seafood, dairy, frozen foods, bakery products and packaged foods have their own areas.

Look for an **international or world foods aisle** for ingredients from different regions. Cultural and specialty grocery stores may offer a wider selection of familiar ingredients.

Understand the Price Tag

Do not compare products using the package price alone. A larger package may cost more but provide better value.

Look for the **unit price**, when displayed, which shows the cost per amount—for example, per 100 g or kilogram. This makes it easier to compare different brands and package sizes.

Also watch for sale conditions such as **“2 for \$6.”** Check the shelf label to see whether you must purchase two items to receive the advertised price.

Compare Store Brands

Many supermarkets sell their own store-brand products alongside well-known brands. Store brands can be less expensive while serving the same purpose.

Compare the **Nutrition Facts table, ingredient list, package size and unit price** rather than assuming the more expensive brand is the better choice.

Look Beyond Fresh Produce

Fresh fruits and vegetables are not the only options.

Frozen produce can be useful when certain foods are out of season, while **canned vegetables, beans, lentils and fish** can provide convenient, longer-lasting alternatives. Check food labels when comparing products, particularly for sodium and added sugars.

Find Substitutes for Familiar Ingredients

If an ingredient from home is unavailable or expensive, think about **how it is used in the meal**.

A similar vegetable may provide the texture needed for a soup or stew. Another grain may work with the same sauce. Frozen ingredients may replace fresh ones, and beans or lentils may work as alternative protein sources in some recipes.

The substitute does not have to be identical—it needs to work for the dish while remaining practical for your household.

Shop With the Seasons

The price and availability of fresh produce can change throughout the year in Canada. Foods that are inexpensive during summer may cost considerably more during winter.

Choosing produce that is in season, buying frozen alternatives, checking weekly specials and adapting recipes around what is available can help manage grocery costs.

Before You Shop

A simple grocery list can make shopping easier and reduce unnecessary purchases. Check what is already at home, plan a few meals, and identify which ingredients can be used across several dishes.

When comparing unfamiliar products, ask:

What do I need this ingredient for?

How much am I getting for the price?

Is there a store-brand or alternative option?

Can I use frozen, canned or seasonal instead?

Understanding these small details can make grocery shopping in Canada easier, more affordable and less dependent on finding an exact version of every familiar food.

Nutrition for Children, Adults and Pregnant Women

A balanced diet provides the carbohydrates, protein, fats, vitamins, minerals, fibre and water the body needs to function well. These nutrients come from different foods, and the amount needed changes with age, activity level, pregnancy and individual health needs.

Canada's Food Guide provides a useful foundation: include **vegetables and fruits, whole-grain foods and protein foods**, and choose water as the main drink. The same basic approach applies across life stages, but some nutrients require greater attention.

Children: Nutrition for Growth and Development

Children need nutritious foods to support growth, brain development, strong bones, physical activity and learning. Because children have smaller stomachs, regular meals and snacks can help provide enough energy and nutrients throughout the day.

Important foods include:

Protein foods such as eggs, beans, lentils, fish, poultry, meat, tofu, yogurt and other suitable options to support growth and tissue development.

Vegetables and fruits for fibre, vitamins and minerals.

Whole-grain foods such as oats, whole-grain bread and brown rice for energy and fibre.

Calcium and vitamin D sources are particularly important while bones and teeth are developing.

Iron-rich foods such as meat, fish, eggs, beans, lentils and iron-fortified foods support healthy growth and development.

Children's nutritional needs change considerably from infancy through adolescence. Parents and caregivers should follow age-appropriate feeding guidance, particularly for infants and very young children.

Adults: Nutrition for Health and Everyday Life

For adults, balanced eating helps provide energy for daily activities while supporting heart, digestive, bone and overall health.

Meals can include a variety of **vegetables and fruits, whole grains and protein foods**, including plant-based proteins such as beans and lentils. Foods rich in fibre can support digestive health, while adequate protein helps maintain muscles and other body tissues.

Adults should also be mindful of foods high in **sodium, sugars and saturated fat**, particularly when these foods make up a large part of the regular diet.

Nutritional needs are not identical for every adult. Age, activity level, health conditions, medications and cultural eating patterns can all influence food choices.

Pregnancy: Nutrition for Parent and Baby

Pregnancy increases the need for certain nutrients to support changes in the pregnant person's body and the baby's growth and development.

A varied diet remains important, with particular attention to nutrients such as:

Folate — important for early development. Canadian guidance recommends a daily multivitamin containing folic acid before and during pregnancy.

Iron — needs increase during pregnancy because the body produces additional blood and iron is required for the developing baby.

Calcium and vitamin D — support bone and tooth development while also helping maintain the pregnant person's bone health.

Protein — supports the growth of maternal and fetal tissues.

Pregnancy also requires additional attention to **food safety**. Some foods carry a greater risk of foodborne illness or exposure to substances that may be harmful during pregnancy. Health Canada

provides specific guidance on foods to limit or avoid, safe food preparation and choosing fish that is lower in mercury.

Traditional Foods Can Remain Part of the Diet

Balanced eating does not require replacing cultural foods.

Beans, lentils, rice, grains, vegetables, fruits, fish, eggs, meats, soups, stews and other traditional foods can provide many of the nutrients needed across different life stages.

What changes is often the **nutritional emphasis**:

Children → growth, development, iron, calcium and adequate energy

Adults → balanced nutrition, fibre, protein and long-term health

Pregnancy → balanced nutrition with increased attention to folate, iron, calcium, vitamin D, protein and food safety

Individual nutritional needs can differ, particularly during pregnancy, infancy or when managing a health condition. A healthcare provider or registered dietitian can provide guidance when more individualized nutrition support is needed.

Understanding Consent and Boundaries

Consent means freely agreeing to something. It is an important part of healthy and respectful relationships, including friendships, dating relationships, healthcare interactions, and physical or sexual relationships.

Consent should be **clear, voluntary and ongoing**. A person should be able to make a choice without being pressured, threatened, manipulated or made to feel that they have no other option.

What Does Consent Look Like?

Consent involves communication and respect. A person can agree to one activity without agreeing to another, and agreeing in the past does not mean consent has been given for the future.

Consent can also be **changed or withdrawn at any time**. If someone changes their mind, the other person should stop and respect that decision.

Silence, hesitation or a lack of resistance should not be assumed to mean agreement.

Understanding Personal Boundaries

Boundaries are the limits people set around what they are comfortable with. They can relate to physical contact, personal space, relationships, privacy, communication and sharing personal information.

For example, someone may be comfortable discussing a personal issue with a close friend but not with a coworker. Another person may not want to be hugged or touched, even when the gesture is intended to be friendly.

Boundaries differ from person to person. Respecting them means listening when someone communicates what they are or are not comfortable with.

Consent in Healthcare

Consent is also part of receiving healthcare in Canada. Healthcare providers should explain a proposed examination, test or treatment and provide information needed for the patient to make an informed decision.

Patients can ask questions, request clarification and discuss concerns before agreeing to care. Consent to one procedure does not automatically mean consent to every procedure.

For newcomers who are unfamiliar with Canadian healthcare practices, knowing that questions and conversations about consent are a normal part of healthcare can make medical appointments easier to navigate.

Culture and Communication

Ideas about personal space, relationships, privacy and discussing sensitive subjects can vary across cultures and families.

Learning about consent does not require giving up cultural values. It provides a shared way of communicating choices and respecting another person's comfort and autonomy.

A useful principle is simple: **when you are unsure whether someone is comfortable, ask rather than assume.**

Healthy relationships—whether personal, social or healthcare-related—are built on communication, respect and the ability for everyone involved to make their own choices.

Navigating Healthy Relationships

Relationships are an important part of growing up. They can include friendships, family relationships, classmates, teammates, online connections and dating relationships.

A healthy relationship should provide room to **be yourself, communicate openly, set boundaries and feel respected.** Disagreements can happen in any relationship, but they should be handled without intimidation, pressure or controlling behaviour.

What Does a Healthy Relationship Look Like?

Respect

Both people value each other's opinions, feelings, culture, interests and boundaries. You should be able to disagree without being insulted, embarrassed or made to feel afraid.

Trust

Trust develops when people are honest and respect each other's privacy and independence. Being close to someone does not mean they need constant access to your phone, messages, passwords, location or social media accounts.

Communication

Healthy communication includes being able to talk about concerns, listen to each other and ask

questions when something is unclear. It should also be possible to say “no,” “I don't like that,” or “I need some space” without being pressured.

Boundaries and consent

Everyone has different limits around physical contact, personal information, time, communication and relationships. These boundaries should be respected. Consent should be freely given and can be changed at any time.

Independence

A healthy relationship should leave room for other parts of life. Teens should still be able to spend time with friends and family, participate in activities, focus on school and have interests outside the relationship.

Recognizing Unhealthy Behaviour

Some behaviours may indicate that a relationship is becoming unhealthy. These can include repeatedly checking someone's phone, demanding passwords, controlling who they spend time with, pressuring them to do things they are uncomfortable with, frequent insults, threats, extreme jealousy or trying to isolate them from friends and family.

Digital behaviour matters too. Sharing private messages or images without permission, repeatedly contacting someone after they have asked for space or using technology to monitor another person are not signs of a healthy relationship.

Handling Disagreements

Conflict does not automatically make a relationship unhealthy. What matters is **how the disagreement is handled**.

Healthy conflict allows both people to explain their perspective, listen, take time apart when needed and work toward a solution without humiliation, threats or pressure.

It is also okay for people to decide that a friendship or dating relationship is no longer right for them.

Relationships Across Cultures

For newcomer youth, relationships may sometimes involve navigating different expectations at home, at school and among friends.

Ideas about dating, friendships, gender roles, privacy and independence can vary between families and cultures. These differences can lead to misunderstandings between young people and their families.

Learning about relationships in Canada does not mean abandoning family or cultural values. It can involve understanding different expectations, communicating respectfully and recognizing that personal boundaries and safety remain important in every relationship.

If Something Does Not Feel Right

A young person does not have to handle a difficult relationship alone.

Talking with a trusted adult—such as a parent or caregiver, teacher, school counsellor, healthcare provider or another trusted support person—can help them understand what is happening and consider appropriate next steps.

A simple question can also help when thinking about a relationship:

Can I be myself, set boundaries, communicate openly and feel respected around this person?

Healthy relationships should support a young person's well-being rather than make them feel controlled, pressured or unsafe.

STI Awareness: Protecting Your Sexual Health

Sexually transmitted infections (STIs) are infections that can be passed between people through sexual contact. Some STIs cause noticeable symptoms, while others may cause few or no symptoms at all. This means a person can have an infection without knowing it, making prevention and testing important parts of sexual healthcare.

STI awareness is not only about avoiding infection. It is about having reliable information, knowing how to reduce risk, recognizing when testing may be appropriate, and understanding where to seek confidential healthcare.

Reduce the Risk of STIs

Different infections spread in different ways, so no single prevention method covers every situation. Prevention may include using condoms or other barrier methods correctly, getting recommended vaccinations such as HPV and hepatitis B vaccines, having open conversations with partners about sexual health, and accessing regular STI testing when appropriate.

Some infections can be prevented or treated with additional medical options. A healthcare professional or sexual-health clinic can explain which prevention strategies are appropriate based on an individual's circumstances.

Testing Matters—Even Without Symptoms

It is possible to have an STI and feel completely well. Testing can identify infections earlier and allow treatment or follow-up before complications develop or an infection is unknowingly passed to someone else.

Testing may be considered after a possible exposure, when beginning a new sexual relationship, when a partner has been diagnosed with an STI, or when recommended by a healthcare provider.

STI testing can involve different types of samples depending on the infection being tested for. A healthcare provider can explain which tests are appropriate and when they should be completed.

If You Notice a Change

Unusual changes or concerns related to sexual health should be discussed with a healthcare professional rather than diagnosed from symptoms alone. Many symptoms can have causes unrelated to an STI, and some STIs have no symptoms.

Family doctors, nurse practitioners and sexual-health clinics can provide testing, treatment, vaccination, prevention information and guidance about notifying partners when necessary.

Sexual Health Care Should Be Confidential and Respectful

For newcomers and young people, concerns about privacy, cultural expectations or embarrassment can make it harder to ask questions about sexual health.

Sexual healthcare is healthcare. Patients can ask what information will remain confidential, what a test involves, why it is recommended and what the results mean. Healthcare providers can also discuss prevention without assuming a person's relationship status, background or sexual experience.

Know Before You Need Care

Knowing where sexual-health services are available makes it easier to seek care when needed. The goal is informed decision-making: **understand how infections are transmitted, reduce preventable risks, test when appropriate and seek healthcare without stigma.**

Protection and Prevention for Youth & Young Adults

Taking care of sexual health means having accurate information and knowing how to reduce preventable risks. For teens and young adults, this includes understanding consent, preventing sexually transmitted infections (STIs), preventing unintended pregnancy, and knowing when and where to seek healthcare.

Know How to Protect Yourself

Use protection consistently.

Condoms and other barrier methods can reduce the risk of many STIs when used correctly. Condoms can also help prevent pregnancy. Other birth-control methods may prevent pregnancy but do not necessarily protect against STIs.

Learn about vaccination.

Vaccines can prevent some infections that may be transmitted through sexual contact, including HPV and hepatitis B. A healthcare provider can help determine which vaccines are recommended based on age and vaccination history.

Consider STI testing.

Some STIs may have no noticeable symptoms. Testing is an important way to know your status and receive treatment when needed. A healthcare provider or sexual-health clinic can advise when testing is appropriate.

Talk about sexual health.

Conversations about boundaries, protection, contraception and STI testing can be part of healthy relationships. Decisions should be made without pressure, and everyone involved has the right to set or change their boundaries.

Use reliable health information.

Social media, friends and online forums can contain misleading sexual-health information. For questions about contraception, STI prevention, testing or symptoms, use trusted public-health resources or speak with a qualified healthcare professional.

Remember: Pregnancy and STI Prevention Are Different

A method that prevents pregnancy may not protect against STIs. Birth-control options such as the pill, implant or intrauterine device (IUD) are designed primarily to prevent pregnancy, while condoms can also reduce the risk of many STIs.

A healthcare professional can explain available options and help someone understand which approach is appropriate for their needs.

Know Where to Get Support

Sexual-health questions are healthcare questions. Youth and young adults can seek information and services from family doctors, nurse practitioners, sexual-health clinics, community health centres, pharmacies and other appropriate health services.

Depending on the service and location, support may include **contraception information, STI testing and treatment, vaccination, pregnancy testing and sexual-health education.**

If privacy is a concern, ask the healthcare provider to explain **how confidentiality works and whether there are any limits** before sharing personal information.

Make Informed Choices

Protection and prevention are not about fear or judgment. They are about having enough information to make decisions about your health.

Know your options. Ask questions. Respect boundaries. Use appropriate protection. Get tested when recommended. Seek healthcare when you need it.

Birth Control Options for Youth & Young Adults

Birth control, also called contraception, helps prevent pregnancy. There are several options, and the best choice can depend on health needs, how often the method needs to be used, personal preference, cost and access to healthcare.

Understanding the differences can help young people ask informed questions when speaking with a healthcare provider.

Condoms

Condoms are used during sexual activity to help prevent pregnancy. They also provide protection against many sexually transmitted infections (STIs), which makes them different from most other birth-control methods.

Birth Control Pills

Birth control pills contain hormones that help prevent pregnancy and are taken on a regular schedule. Different types of pills are available, and a healthcare provider can help determine whether they are appropriate based on a person's health and medical history.

Important: Birth control pills do not protect against STIs.

IUD — Intrauterine Device

An IUD is a small device placed in the uterus by a healthcare professional. Hormonal and non-hormonal options are available, and depending on the type, an IUD can provide pregnancy prevention for several years.

It can also be removed by a healthcare professional when pregnancy prevention is no longer wanted.

IUDs do not protect against STIs.

Birth Control Implant

The contraceptive implant is a small device placed under the skin of the upper arm by a healthcare professional. It releases a hormone and provides long-lasting pregnancy prevention without requiring something to be taken every day.

The implant does not protect against STIs.

Emergency Contraception

Emergency contraception can help prevent pregnancy after unprotected sexual activity or when another birth-control method did not work as intended.

Options include emergency contraceptive pills and, in some circumstances, certain IUDs. Because timing and suitability can vary, a pharmacist or healthcare provider can provide guidance about available options.

Emergency contraception is intended to **prevent pregnancy; it does not end an established pregnancy and does not protect against STIs.**

Choosing a Birth Control Method

There is no single birth-control method that is right for everyone. A healthcare provider or pharmacist can explain **effectiveness, possible side effects, STI protection, cost and how each method is accessed.**

It is also important to remember that most birth-control methods prevent pregnancy but **do not prevent STIs.** Condoms can help reduce the risk of many STIs and may be used alongside another contraceptive method.

Learning about contraception is part of understanding sexual health. Young people can ask questions, discuss their options with a healthcare professional and make informed decisions about their health and boundaries.

Gender Identity and Inclusivity

Canada is home to people with different cultures, identities, families and life experiences. In healthcare, everyone should be treated with dignity and respect and have access to care without discrimination.

Understanding gender identity and inclusive healthcare can help newcomers and young people communicate more comfortably with healthcare providers and understand what respectful care should look like.

Understanding Gender Identity

Gender identity refers to a person's internal sense of their gender. A person may identify as a woman, man, non-binary, or another gender. Gender identity is different from biological characteristics and from sexual orientation.

People may express their gender through clothing, names, pronouns or other aspects of their appearance and everyday life. Not everyone expresses or experiences gender in the same way.

What Does Inclusive Healthcare Mean?

Inclusive healthcare recognizes that patients have different identities, cultures, languages and experiences.

In practice, this can mean healthcare providers:

communicate respectfully and avoid assumptions about a patient's identity or relationships;

use the patient's name and pronouns appropriately;

explain examinations, tests and treatment before proceeding;

provide relevant health information based on the person's individual needs;

respect privacy and confidentiality within applicable rules; and

provide care without judgment or discrimination.

Patients can also ask questions if they do not understand why personal information is being requested or how it relates to their healthcare.

Respect Works Both Ways

Inclusive communities do not require everyone to have the same experiences, beliefs or cultural background. They do require people to treat one another with dignity.

For newcomers, some language or conversations around gender may be unfamiliar. Learning what terms mean can make it easier to understand healthcare forms, school information and conversations with healthcare professionals without requiring someone to already know every term.

Accessing Care

If a young person has questions about their body, gender, relationships or general health, they can speak with an appropriate healthcare professional or trusted support service.

Good healthcare should create space for questions and provide clear, evidence-based information so that patients can understand their options and participate in decisions about their health.

Everyone deserves healthcare that is safe, respectful and responsive to their individual needs.

Understanding Public Health in Canada

Public health is the part of the health system that works to **prevent illness, promote well-being and protect communities**. While doctors and clinics often focus on the health needs of individual patients, public health looks at health concerns that can affect families, neighbourhoods and entire communities.

For someone new to Canada, public health may already be part of everyday life. Vaccination programs, food inspections, school health services, drinking-water advisories, disease outbreak notices and information about extreme weather or air quality are all examples of public health in action.

Public Health Protects Communities

Public health helps identify and respond to health risks before they affect more people. Health authorities monitor concerns such as infectious diseases, food and water safety, environmental hazards and other issues that may affect community health.

When necessary, public-health authorities may issue alerts or recommendations so people know what is happening and what precautions to take.

Prevention Helps Reduce Illness

Preventing illness is a major part of public health. Vaccination, screening, infection prevention, safe food practices and early detection can help reduce the spread of disease and identify health concerns earlier.

Newcomers who have vaccination records from another country should keep them and bring them when accessing healthcare. A healthcare provider or public-health professional can review the records and identify whether additional vaccines are recommended.

Health Education Improves Well-being

Public health also helps people make informed decisions about their health. Programs may provide information about nutrition, physical activity, sexual health, pregnancy, child development, mental well-being, substance use, disease prevention and environmental health.

Reliable health information can be especially useful when adjusting to a healthcare system that works differently from the one you are familiar with.

Everyone Plays a Role in Community Health

Public health is a shared effort. Everyday actions—such as following food-safety practices, staying up to date with recommended vaccinations, following public-health advisories and taking appropriate steps to prevent the spread of infections—can help protect both individuals and the people around them.

Community health is also shaped by access to safe housing, clean water, nutritious food, education, healthcare and supportive environments. Public health works with communities and other services to address these broader influences on health.

Key Points to Remember

Public health protects communities by identifying health risks and supporting safer environments.

Prevention helps reduce illness through measures such as vaccination, screening and infection prevention.

Health education improves well-being by giving people reliable information to make informed health decisions.

Everyone plays a role in community health through individual actions, community participation and shared responsibility for healthier environments.

Understanding public health can help newcomers recognize important health information, know when an advisory applies to them and make better use of the programs and services available in their community.

Vaccines and Immunization in Canada

Vaccines help protect people from serious infectious diseases by preparing the immune system to recognize and respond to specific infections. Immunization is an important part of preventive healthcare in Canada and is recommended at different stages of life, from childhood through adulthood.

For newcomers, vaccination recommendations in Canada may differ from those in another country. Previous vaccination records can help healthcare providers determine which vaccines have already been received and whether any additional doses are recommended.

What Do Vaccines Protect Against?

Vaccines are available for a range of preventable diseases. Depending on a person's age, health, vaccination history and other factors, recommended vaccines may include protection against:

Influenza (flu) — vaccination is recommended regularly because circulating influenza viruses can change over time.

COVID-19 — vaccination recommendations are updated as public-health guidance and available vaccines change.

Measles — a highly contagious infection that can cause serious complications. Protection is commonly provided through combination vaccines such as MMR.

Hepatitis — vaccines are available against hepatitis A and hepatitis B. Recommendations depend on factors such as age, previous immunization and risk.

Tetanus — protection is usually provided as part of combination vaccines, with booster doses recommended at certain times.

HPV (Human Papillomavirus) — vaccination helps protect against HPV infections that can lead to several types of cancer and other health conditions.

New to Canada? Check Your Immunization Record

If you have vaccination records from your home country, keep them and bring them to a healthcare provider or public-health clinic. Even if the record uses different vaccine names or schedules, it may help determine your vaccination history.

If records are unavailable or incomplete, a healthcare professional can explain what steps may be appropriate rather than assuming that every vaccination needs to be restarted.

Are Vaccines Free in Canada?

Many recommended vaccines are publicly funded, meaning eligible people can receive them without paying directly. However, **coverage varies by province or territory, age, health needs and the vaccine being provided.**

Vaccines may be available through public-health clinics, family doctors, pharmacies, schools or other healthcare services, depending on where you live.

Key Points

Vaccines help prevent disease.

Immunization reduces the risk of many vaccine-preventable illnesses and their complications.

Immunization protects communities.

When more people are protected against an infection, there are fewer opportunities for some diseases to spread, which can also help protect people who are more vulnerable.

Some vaccines are provided free in Canada.

Publicly funded vaccines vary across provinces and territories, so check the immunization program where you live.

Speak with a healthcare provider about vaccines.

A doctor, nurse, pharmacist or public-health professional can review your vaccination history and explain which vaccines are recommended for you.

Keeping an immunization record and checking provincial recommendations can make it easier to stay up to date as you settle in Canada.

Understanding Communicable Diseases

Communicable diseases are illnesses caused by infectious organisms such as viruses, bacteria, fungi or parasites that can spread between people or through contaminated food, water, surfaces, animals or insects.

Knowing **how an infection spreads** is important because the precautions needed for one disease may be different from another. Public-health guidance, vaccination, hygiene and early healthcare can all help reduce the spread of infection within families and communities.

Understand the Types of Communicable Diseases

Communicable diseases can be grouped by how they are transmitted.

Respiratory infections can spread through infectious particles released when people breathe, talk, cough or sneeze. Examples include influenza, COVID-19 and tuberculosis.

Food- and water-borne infections can occur when food or water becomes contaminated. Examples include norovirus, salmonellosis and hepatitis A.

Direct-contact infections can spread through close contact with an infected person or, for some infections, contaminated objects or surfaces. Examples include certain skin infections.

Vector-borne diseases are transmitted by organisms such as mosquitoes and ticks. Examples include Lyme disease and West Nile virus, both of which occur in Canada.

Blood and body-fluid infections can spread through specific exposures to infected blood or other body fluids. Examples include hepatitis B, hepatitis C and HIV.

Safety Measures Against Infection

Prevention depends on how a particular infection spreads. Everyday measures such as **washing hands thoroughly, following safe food-handling practices, covering coughs and sneezes, and avoiding close contact with others when sick** can reduce the spread of many infections.

Vaccination also provides protection against several communicable diseases. Other precautions may include using insect repellent and checking for ticks, practising safer sex, and avoiding the sharing of personal items that could be contaminated with blood.

During an outbreak, local public-health authorities may recommend additional precautions based on the disease and level of risk.

Necessary Safety Precautions

Knowing when to act is just as important as knowing how infections spread. Pay attention to public-health notices, food recalls, vaccination recommendations and local disease advisories.

If you develop symptoms or know you have been exposed to an infectious disease, contact an appropriate healthcare service for guidance. Depending on the infection, you may be advised to stay home, get tested, receive treatment or take additional precautions around other people.

Extra care may be needed around people who are more likely to become seriously ill from certain infections, including infants, older adults and some people with underlying health conditions.

Follow-Up and Treatment

Treatment is different for every communicable disease. Some infections improve with supportive care, while others require specific medicines or ongoing medical follow-up. Antibiotics treat certain **bacterial infections**, but they do not treat viral infections such as influenza.

If treatment is prescribed, follow the healthcare provider's instructions and attend recommended follow-up appointments. Follow-up may be used to check recovery, review test results, manage complications or determine whether additional testing or treatment is needed.

Some communicable diseases must also be reported to public health. In these situations, public-health professionals may contact the person to provide guidance and identify whether others may have been exposed.

Key Points

Understand how diseases spread. Different communicable diseases require different prevention measures.

Use the right safety measures. Vaccination, hygiene, safe food practices and other precautions can reduce the risk of infection.

Respond appropriately when illness occurs. Follow public-health guidance and take precautions to reduce spreading an infection to others.

Complete treatment and follow-up. Seek healthcare when needed, follow treatment instructions and attend recommended follow-up appointments.

Understanding communicable diseases makes it easier to recognize risks, take appropriate precautions and know when to seek healthcare or public-health support.

Understanding Seasonal Health Risks in Canada

Canada experiences four distinct seasons—**winter, spring, summer and fall**—but weather conditions vary considerably across the country. Temperatures can shift from extreme cold in winter to periods of intense heat in summer, while changes in air quality, allergens, insects and infectious diseases can also occur throughout the year.

For newcomers, understanding these seasonal changes makes it easier to prepare for the weather and recognize health risks that may be unfamiliar.

Winter: Extreme Cold, Snow and Ice

Canadian winters can bring freezing temperatures, heavy snowfall, strong winds and icy conditions. Exposure to extreme cold can lead to cold-related illness, while snow and ice increase the risk of slips, falls and transportation difficulties.

Dress in warm layers and use appropriate winter clothing, including insulated footwear, gloves or mittens and head covering. Check weather warnings before travelling and limit prolonged exposure during extreme cold.

Winter is also associated with increased circulation of respiratory infections such as influenza. Following current vaccination recommendations, washing hands regularly and taking appropriate precautions when sick can help reduce transmission.

Spring: Allergies, Changing Weather and Ticks

Spring temperatures can change quickly as warmer weather returns. Pollen from trees and other plants may trigger seasonal allergies, causing symptoms such as sneezing, congestion and irritated or watery eyes.

Ticks also become more active as temperatures rise. When spending time in wooded, grassy or brush-covered areas, use appropriate insect protection and check clothing, skin and pets for ticks afterward.

Summer: Heat, Sun and Air Quality

Periods of high temperatures can increase the risk of heat-related illness, particularly during heat waves. Staying hydrated, reducing strenuous activity during the hottest part of the day and spending time in cooler environments can help manage heat exposure.

Sun protection is also important. Shade, suitable clothing and sunscreen can reduce exposure to ultraviolet (UV) radiation.

Wildfire smoke and poor air quality can affect some Canadian communities during warmer months. Check local air-quality information and follow public-health advice when smoke or other air-quality concerns are present.

Fall: Cooler Weather and Respiratory Illness

Fall brings shorter days and gradually cooler temperatures. It is also a useful time to prepare for winter and check seasonal health recommendations.

Respiratory infections often become more common during the colder months. Public-health authorities may provide updated recommendations for seasonal vaccines, including influenza and COVID-19 vaccination.

Having appropriate winter clothing and basic emergency supplies ready before severe winter weather begins can also make the transition into winter easier.

Managing Seasonal Health Risks

Canada's weather can change quickly, so preparation should begin before conditions become severe. Check local forecasts and weather alerts, dress for current conditions and learn which health risks are common in your region.

Seasonal health management may include **vaccination, hydration, sun protection, insect and tick protection, appropriate clothing, monitoring air quality and preparing for extreme weather.**

Health risks also vary between provinces and communities. Local public-health authorities and Environment and Climate Change Canada provide regional information when extreme weather or environmental conditions may affect health.

Key Points

Understand Canada's seasonal changes. Each season brings different weather and environmental conditions, and the risks can vary depending on where you live.

Prepare for seasonal health risks. Appropriate clothing, hydration, vaccination, sun protection, insect protection and weather awareness can help reduce preventable health problems.

Pay attention to local conditions. Weather alerts, air-quality information and public-health notices can help you respond to changing conditions before they become a health concern.

Learning how Canada's seasons affect everyday health can make seasonal changes easier to anticipate and safer to navigate.

Safety During Extreme Weather in Canada

Canada's weather can change quickly, and some conditions can become dangerous. Depending on where you live, you may experience **winter storms, extreme cold, heat waves, thunderstorms, flooding, wildfire smoke or other severe weather events.**

For newcomers who have not experienced these conditions before, knowing what to expect and preparing ahead of time can reduce health and safety risks.

Extreme Cold and Winter Storms

Winter storms can bring very low temperatures, heavy snow, strong winds, freezing rain and poor visibility. Severe weather can also disrupt transportation and, occasionally, electricity or other services.

Cold exposure can lead to serious health problems, while snow and ice increase the risk of falls and injuries.

During extreme cold:

Check the weather forecast and warnings before leaving home.

Dress in several warm layers and protect exposed skin with appropriate winter clothing.

Wear insulated, slip-resistant footwear when conditions are icy.

Limit unnecessary time outdoors during extreme cold or severe storms.

Keep basic supplies at home in case travel becomes difficult.

Avoid unnecessary travel when authorities advise people to stay off the roads.

If someone develops concerning symptoms after prolonged cold exposure, move indoors and seek appropriate medical help.

Heat Waves and Extreme Heat

Canadian summers can also include periods of very high temperatures and humidity. During a heat wave, the body may have difficulty cooling itself, increasing the risk of heat-related illness.

Stay hydrated throughout the day and spend time in air-conditioned or cooler spaces when possible. Reduce strenuous outdoor activity during the hottest parts of the day and never leave children, pets or other vulnerable people inside a parked vehicle.

Pay particular attention to local heat warnings and check on family members or others who may have difficulty managing extreme heat.

Wildfire Smoke and Poor Air Quality

Wildfire smoke can travel long distances and affect air quality even in communities far from the fire itself. Smoke can irritate the eyes and respiratory system and may affect some people more severely.

When air quality is poor, check local air-quality information and follow public-health recommendations. This may include reducing strenuous outdoor activity or spending more time indoors when smoke levels are high.

Storms, Flooding and Power Outages

Severe thunderstorms, heavy rainfall, flooding and high winds can create additional risks. Avoid flooded roads and areas, stay away from downed power lines and follow evacuation or emergency instructions from local authorities.

Power outages can also affect heating, cooling, food storage and medical equipment. Keeping a basic emergency kit with essentials such as water, non-perishable food, a flashlight, batteries and necessary medications can help households manage short disruptions.

Know the Health Risks

Extreme weather can affect health in different ways.

Extreme cold can cause cold-related illness and make icy conditions more dangerous.

Extreme heat can lead to dehydration and heat-related illness.

Wildfire smoke and poor air quality can affect breathing and worsen some existing respiratory or cardiovascular conditions.

Storms, ice and flooding can increase the risk of falls, injuries, transportation problems and disruptions to essential services.

Understanding these risks makes it easier to recognize when weather conditions require additional precautions.

Key Points

Be familiar with Canada's seasons and weather changes. Conditions can change quickly, and the type of extreme weather varies by season and region.

Understand safety measures for extreme weather. Check official weather alerts, prepare appropriate clothing and supplies, and follow instructions from local authorities.

Know the health risks associated with seasonal changes. Extreme cold, heat, poor air quality and severe storms can affect health differently, so precautions should match the conditions.

Preparation does not need to begin when an emergency happens. **Knowing your local weather risks, checking alerts and having basic supplies ready can make extreme weather easier and safer to manage.**